

In the end, wrote Vasari, Leonardo painted “a great animal so horrible and fearful that it seemed to poison the air with its fiery breath, with venom issuing from its open jaws, fire from its eyes, and smoke from its nostrils.”

But was it really scary enough? Leonardo wanted to make sure. One morning, he placed the shield on an easel by the window, so that a shaft of soft light fell on the painting. When his father first saw it, he was startled, thinking it was not just a painting, but rather a truly terrifying beast. This pleased Leonardo, who told his father to take the painted shield, since “the work answers the purpose for which it was made.”

Eventually, if his talents progressed well, an apprentice might be considered skilled enough to actually help paint some parts of his master’s canvas. However, a master



DID YOU
KNOW?

The shield was later sold to the Duke of Milan, who kept it safely away from any battle and admired it as a work of art.